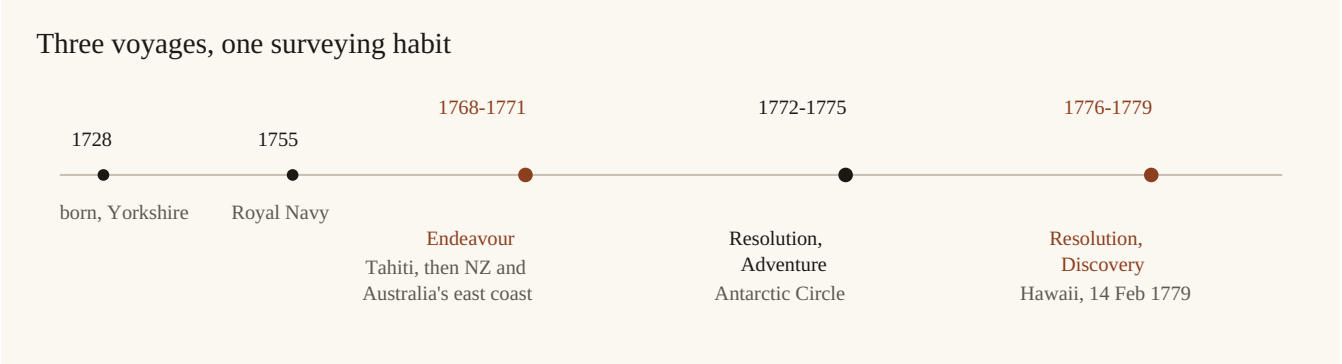
FARIA · 7 NOVEMBER 2026 · A LESSON FOR JEFF FRANZEN

Captain James Cook: precision, encounter, and empire

James Cook was born in Yorkshire in 1728. He learned the sea in the coal trade, then joined the Royal Navy in 1755. Before any Pacific voyage he surveyed Newfoundland. The Navy already trusted him to draw a coast so that the next ship could use the drawing.

In 1768 the Admiralty gave him Endeavour. The announced task was the transit of Venus, 3 June 1769, at Tahiti, with the astronomer Charles Green. Joseph Banks and Daniel Solander sailed to collect and classify. Cook commanded, and he surveyed. After Tahiti he opened sealed instructions to sail farther and to chart what he found. In 1769 and 1770 he charted New Zealand and the east coast of Australia. Those shores were not empty, and they were not unknown to the people who lived there. A European chart is a new record for London. It is not the first knowledge of a place.



Cook's three Pacific voyages on a timeline

Three commissions, drawn for this lesson. The first includes the Tahiti transit and the charts of New Zealand and eastern Australia. The second crosses the Antarctic Circle. The third looks for a northern passage.

The second voyage, 1772 to 1775, in Resolution and Adventure, crossed the Antarctic Circle. Cook put an end to the hope of a green southern continent sitting in the temperate ocean. He did not claim to have seen the mainland of Antarctica.

The third voyage, 1776 to 1779, in Resolution and Discovery, searched for a passage in the north. In 1778 the ships reached Hawaii. On 14 February 1779, at Kealakekua Bay, Cook was killed as a relationship that had already turned violent broke apart. The charts stayed in the Navy's hands. So did the harder consequence: disease, weapons, and later colonial power traveled along the same routes.

Hold both parts of the man. The angles and the coastlines were careful. The encounters were not a blank page, and they were not a moral slogan in either direction. The transit itself, and the risk of getting the observers there, is the next lesson in this day's chain. Banks, who collected beside him and did not sail the second voyage, is the lesson after that.

The illustrated lesson is download the PDF.

Sources

- Royal Museums Greenwich, "Captain James Cook: timeline," https://www.rmg.co.uk/stories/maritime-history/captain-james-cook-timeline
- Whipple Museum, Cambridge, on the quadrant stolen at Tahiti and recovered: https://www.whipplemuseum.cam.ac.uk/explore-whipple-collections/astronomy-and-empire/stolen-quadrant

Key facts

- Cook, born 1728 in Yorkshire, joined the Royal Navy in 1755 and had already surveyed Newfoundland.
- Endeavour, 1768-1771: Tahiti transit on 3 June 1769 with Green; then charts of New Zealand and Australia's east coast, lands already inhabited.
- Second voyage, 1772-1775, crossed the Antarctic Circle and did not claim a sighting of the Antarctic mainland.
- Third voyage ended at Kealakekua Bay, Hawaii, on 14 February 1779, after relations had turned violent.